Global network

The organization began by setting up a number of internationally recognized protected sites, known as the World Network of Biosphere Reserves (WNBR). These set out to show how human cultural and biological diversity are mutually beneficial and encourage the balanced integration of people with their natural environment. They also sought to find ways to manage natural resources efficiently for the benefit of the environment as well as its inhabitants.

There are now over 750 sites across 136 countries, providing a platform for collaborative scientific and cultural research in a range of marine, coastal, and terrestrial ecosystems. Through the network, the program monitors the effects of human activity on the biosphere, particularly examining climate change, and fosters the exchange of information.

Local knowledge

The MAB program recognizes three interconnected functions of a biosphere reserve: conservation; sustainable development; and support though education and training. These objectives are achieved by zoning areas within the reserve to protect core locations, whilst simultaneously providing places for appropriate and sustainable development by local inhabitants.

To this end, communities are encouraged to participate in the management of the reserve, and use their local knowledge of the area to make the best use of natural resources. The idea of educating people about the environment and sharing knowledge across the World Network is key to the success of the project as a whole.